CLEO · AI GUIDES

AI for Musicians

The complete guide to AI tools for guitarists, producers, and music lovers — with exercises to try today.

Suno · Moises · ChordAI · Hooktheory · iZotope RX · LANDR · Splice · Neutron 4

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INTRODUCTION

AI Has Arrived in Music. Here's What's Actually Worth Using.

The hype around AI in music is enormous and mostly unhelpful. Half the tools being promoted are gimmicks. The other half are genuinely useful but poorly explained. This guide cuts through both.

What you'll find here: specific tools, honest assessments of what they're good at, and step-by-step exercises you can do today. Organised by what you're trying to achieve — because that's how musicians think, not by tool category.

One thing upfront: AI won't make you a better musician. It removes friction, gives you faster access to ideas, and handles tedious technical tasks. Your ears, your taste, and your feel are still entirely yours.

How to use this guide

- Don't try everything at once. Pick one tool. Use it for a week. Then come back.
- The "Try This" sections are the most important part. Do the exercises — don't just read them.
- Some tools are for performance, some for production, some for both. Pick what fits your workflow.
- Everything here has a free tier or trial. Start for $0.

8	35+	$0	3hrs
Tools covered in depth	Exercises to try today	To start with any tool here	Estimated weekly time saved

01 MUSIC GENERATION

Suno

Describe a song in plain English and hear it in 30 seconds — the fastest idea-to-sound tool available

Free · Pro $8/month suno.com

Suno generates full songs — vocals, instrumentation, production — from a plain-English description. Results range from impressive to unusable, but that doesn't matter: you're not using it for finished tracks. The value is speed. An idea that takes 20 minutes to demo on an instrument takes 30 seconds in Suno. You can explore 10 directions before settling on one, which changes how you develop songs.

What it's genuinely excellent at

- **Reference tracks.** Hear what your chord progression sounds like as a full production in a different genre. Faster than any other method.
- **Breaking writer's block.** Generate 10 variations of an idea. You'll dislike most — but one will spark something.
- **Genre exploration.** Want to understand why a reggae groove feels the way it does? Generate one and listen analytically.
- **Lyric sketching.** Often generic but occasionally a phrase lands. Use as a starting point, never a finish line.

⚡ Try This — 5 Exercises to Do Right Now

1. **The genre mashup.** Go to suno.com and describe a song combining your three favourite artists. Be specific: "Driving rock song, 120bpm, Marshall amp tone, anthem feel, [Artist A] meets [Artist B]." Listen to what comes back and identify what works. Use the interesting parts as creative direction — not the output itself.

2. **The 10-variations sprint.** Take one song idea you've been sitting on. Generate 10 versions with slightly different prompts — vary the tempo, mood word, and genre. Do this in under 10 minutes. You'll discover interpretations of your idea you hadn't imagined.

3. **The reference track build.** Think of the production style you want for a song you're working on. Generate a Suno track that captures that vibe. Use it as your production reference when recording and mixing — same function as referencing a commercial track, but tailor-made to your vision.

4. **The prompting experiment.** Take one prompt and generate it four ways: (1) vague, (2) detailed with style, (3) with tempo and key, (4) with a named influence. Compare all four. This teaches you how to prompt effectively — a skill that transfers to every other AI tool.

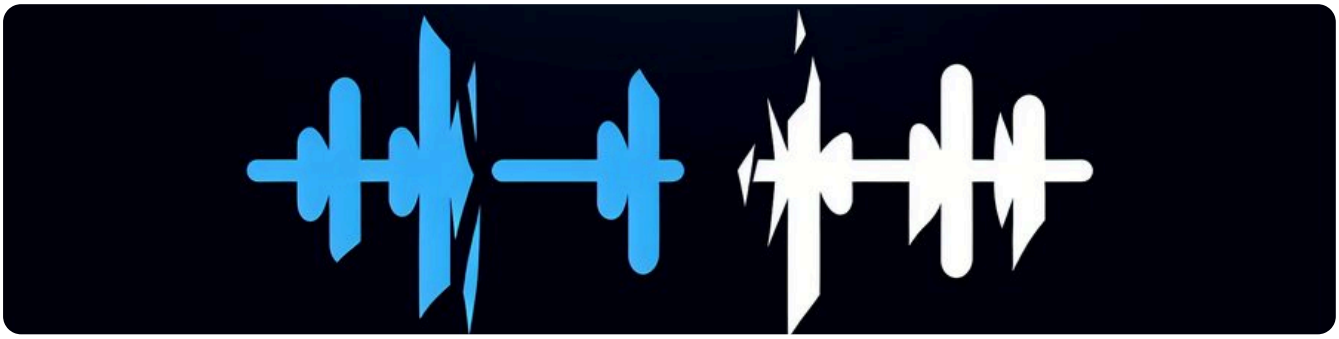
5. **The unexpected genre test.** Take a song you know well and generate it in a completely different genre. Your favourite rock track as bossa nova. Your favourite folk song as drum and bass. Listen analytically — what harmonic or melodic elements survive the translation? This is ear training dressed as experimentation.

Bottom line: Start here. Free tier gives you enough generations per day to evaluate it properly. Use it for ideas and references, not finished products. Upgrade to Pro ($8/month) when you hit the free limit regularly.

02 PRACTICE & LEARNING

Moises

The best practice tool for musicians since the metronome — separate any song into stems instantly



Free (limited) · Premium $3.99/month moises.ai

Moises separates any song into individual stems — vocals, drums, bass, other instruments — and lets you slow it down without changing pitch, transpose to any key, and mute specific parts to create backing tracks. This changes how you practise entirely. Learning by ear used to mean slowing down recordings and guessing. Moises compresses that process to seconds.

The workflows that make this essential

→ **Learning songs.** Mute the instrument you're learning. Play along with the rest of the band. When comfortable, bring it back in to check yourself.

→ **Transcription.** Slow to 50–60% speed, isolate one instrument, loop the difficult section. Far more effective than any other transcription method.

→ **Instant backing tracks.** Mute your instrument from any song and jam along. Infinitely more engaging than a metronome.

→ **Key transposition.** Instantly move any song to suit your vocal range or a more comfortable guitar key.

⚡ Try This — 5 Exercises to Do Right Now

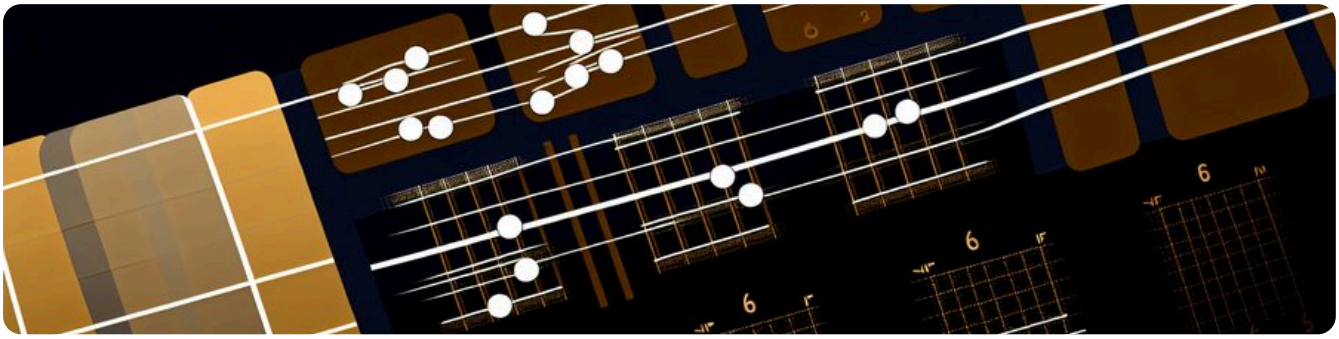
1. **The difficult passage drill.** Upload a song with a section you've struggled to learn. Isolate the instrument, slow to 60%, loop the 4 bars that trip you up. Repeat until clean, then bring the speed back up. Compare this to your previous method.
2. **The backing track session.** Upload your three favourite songs to jam to. Mute your primary instrument from each. Play along for 20 minutes. Notice how much more musical your practice is when you're playing with a real band rather than alone.
3. **The key comfort test.** Find a song you like but avoided because of the key. Use Moises to transpose it 2–3 semitones to a more natural position. Play through it. Expand your repertoire without fighting your instrument.
4. **The bass line excavation.** Pick a song where you've never been sure what the bass is doing. Isolate the bass stem and listen for 5 focused minutes. You'll hear details you've missed despite knowing the song for years. Do the same with drums on a track with a great groove.
5. **The vocal harmony reveal.** Take a song with complex vocal harmonies and mute everything except vocals. How many parts? What intervals? This is ear training that works because it's in music you already love and respond to emotionally.

Bottom line: The single highest-value tool in this guide for practising musicians. $4/month is negligible. If you subscribe to only one tool from this guide, make it this one.

03 CHORD RECOGNITION

ChordAI

Point your phone at any song and know the chords in real time



Free · Pro $4.99/month chord.ai

ChordAI listens to any song — from speakers, headphones, or a recording — and displays the chords in real time as they change. It works from live audio, uploaded files, and YouTube videos. Accuracy is around 85–90% for standard progressions in common genres. What used to take 30–45 minutes of slow repetition now takes 5 minutes. The remaining 10–15% of errors are instructive: AI still misses context, and your ear is the final judge.

Best use cases

→ **Learning songs quickly.** Get the chord framework in minutes, then refine specific voicings by ear.

→ **Songwriting analysis.** Analyse songs you love to understand their harmonic language.

→ **Jamming prep.** Before a session, run the song through ChordAI for a fast overview.

⚡ Try This — 4 Exercises to Do Right Now

1. **The song you've been avoiding.** Pick a song you've wanted to learn but found too hard to work out by ear. Run it through ChordAI. Get the full chord progression in 5 minutes. Now use your ear to verify and refine each chord's voicing. The AI gives you the framework; your ear does the finishing.

2. **The AI vs. your ear comparison.** Before running a song through ChordAI, listen to the chorus and write down your best guess at the chords. Then check against ChordAI. Where were you right? Where wrong? What pattern do you see in your errors? This is the most honest ear training diagnostic you can do.

3. **The songwriting steal.** Take 3 songs from a genre you want to write in. Run each through ChordAI and note the key, chord sequence, and any interesting substitutions. Look for patterns across all three. You now have the harmonic blueprint of that genre to use deliberately in your next composition.

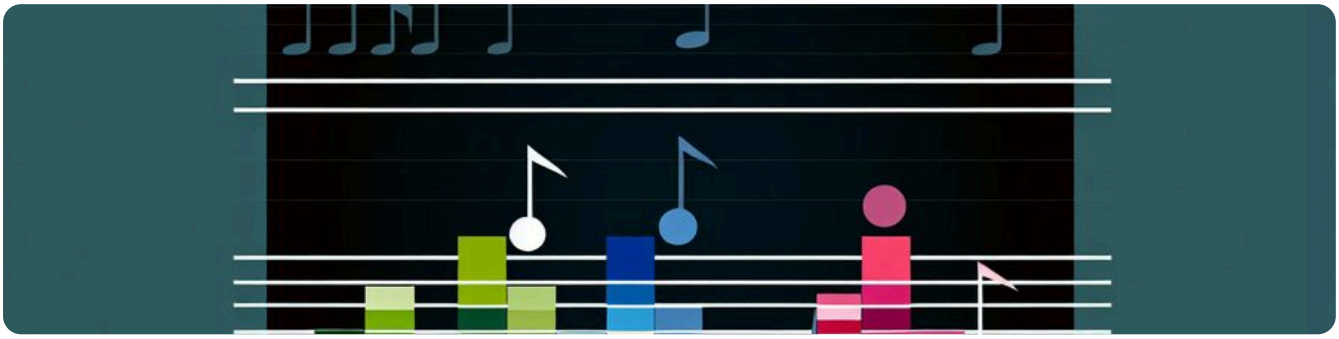
4. **The modulation finder.** Use ChordAI on a song that changes key at some point. Watch where the chords shift to a new tonal centre. Analyse 3–4 examples from different eras and you'll start to see the common modulation techniques professional songwriters rely on.

Bottom line: Essential for guitarists who learn by ear. Pro adds unlimited usage and YouTube analysis — worth it if you're learning more than 2–3 songs per month. Always verify with your ear: that verification process is ear training.

04 MUSIC THEORY

Hooktheory

Understand why the chord progressions you love actually work



Free to browse · Pro $9.99/month hooktheory.com

Hooktheory uses data from thousands of songs to show you music theory in action. The "Trends" tool lets you search for any chord progression and see every famous song that uses it. The "Hookpad" tool is a browser-based composition environment that teaches theory as you write. You don't need to read music notation for any of it. Most theory courses teach you rules. Hooktheory shows you patterns in real music you recognise.

The tools that matter

- → **Trends.** Search any chord progression and hear how the same chords sound across dozens of genres and eras.
- → **Hookpad.** Write progressions and melodies in the browser. The AI shows which chords "fit" based on key and theory, and suggests next chords as you compose.
- → **Books (optional).** Hooktheory I and II use the same data-driven approach. Excellent if you want structured theory study.

⚡ Try This — 4 Exercises to Do Right Now

1. **The progression detective.** Think of a chord progression from a song you love. Go to hooktheory.com/trends and search for those chords. Read the list of songs that use the same progression. Listen to 3–4 of them. Notice how the same harmonic skeleton produces completely different emotional results depending on melody, rhythm, and production. This is theory made audible.

2. **The Hookpad composition session.** Open Hookpad and set a key. Start entering chords. After each chord, look at the "suggested next chord" recommendations and their probability percentages. Choose based on what sounds right to your ear. After 8 bars, play back what you've written. This is the fastest way to understand functional harmony.

3. **The tension analysis.** Find a song with a memorable pre-chorus that builds tension before the chorus releases. Enter the chords into Hooktheory. Look at which scale degrees they use — you'll see how "unstable" chords demand resolution, and how the chorus provides it. Apply this deliberately in your own writing.

4. **The genre comparison.** Pick your favourite chord progression. Search it in Hooktheory Trends and filter by genre. Compare how it's used in pop vs. rock vs. country vs. R&B. The chords are the same — the genre comes from everything else. This is why theory is a tool, not a straitjacket.

Bottom line: Free browsing is enough for serious value. Pro unlocks Hookpad's full features — worth it if you're actively composing. Use it alongside ChordAI: ChordAI tells you what the chords are; Hooktheory tells you why they work.

05 AUDIO REPAIR

iZotope RX

The most practically useful studio AI tool — salvages recordings you thought were ruined

Elements $99 (on sale regularly) · Standard $399 izotope.com

If you record anything at home — vocals, acoustic guitar, live instruments — iZotope RX is the most practically useful AI tool in this guide. It uses machine learning to separate audio into components and remove problems that would otherwise ruin a recording. RX is the difference between scrapping a take because of background noise and keeping it because the performance was right.

Capabilities that actually work

- → **Vocal De-noise.** Remove room noise, HVAC hum, computer fan noise, traffic. Results beat mid-range acoustic treatment for recordings already made.
- → **De-click and De-crackle.** Fix digital glitches, remove mouth clicks, restore old recordings.
- → **Stem Separation.** Separate a mixed song into vocals, drums, bass, and instruments. Usable for learning, remixing, and reference.
- → **Dialogue Isolate.** Extract vocals from a recording with significant background noise.

⚡ Try This — 4 Exercises to Do Right Now

1. **The rescue mission.** Go back through your recordings and find one you abandoned because of background noise or room sound. Download the free RX trial, import the recording, and run De-noise. Compare before and after. Most people are shocked at what's recoverable from recordings they wrote off.

2. **The home studio diagnostic.** Record a short take in your normal setup — nothing special. Import into RX and run Spectral Repair and De-noise. Note what RX finds: room reflections, HVAC noise, electrical hum. This is your environment's acoustic fingerprint. Use it to decide what treatment would help most.

3. **The mouth click hunt.** Take any vocal recording you've done. Play it back loud through headphones and listen for clicks between phrases. Import into RX and use De-click in gentle mode on the whole file. Clean vocals mix better and sit further forward — this step is often skipped and always audible.

4. **The stem separation study.** Take a mixed track you want to learn from. Run it through Music Rebalance and listen to the isolated stems. What reverb is on the snare? What effect is on the guitar? How loud is the bass vs. the kick? You can learn more about production in 20 minutes with RX than from hours of reading about it.

Bottom line: Elements ($99, frequently 50% off) is the right starting point. If you record vocals or acoustic instruments at home, this pays for itself on the first session where it saves a performance you'd have re-recorded. Check izotope.com for sale pricing — it goes on sale several times a year.

06 MASTERING

LANDR

AI mastering in minutes — honest about what it is and what it isn't

Free (watermarked) · Basic $8.99/month landr.com

LANDR analyses your mix and returns a mastered version in minutes — EQ, compression, limiting, and stereo enhancement applied by AI. The honest assessment: LANDR is good enough for demos, social media content, and reference masters. It is not good enough for a commercial release where quality is the differentiator. A human mastering engineer who knows your genre will consistently produce better results for anything that matters.

Where LANDR genuinely earns its keep

- → **Demo turnaround.** Need a polished-sounding demo by tomorrow. LANDR makes it happen in 5 minutes.
- → **Social media content.** Tracks for Instagram, TikTok, or YouTube that need to sit in a feed alongside commercial releases.
- → **Mix diagnostic tool.** Compare your mix against the mastered version — the AI's corrections show you what's thin, harsh, or unbalanced.

⚡ Try This — 4 Exercises to Do Right Now

1. **The mix diagnostic.** Upload your latest mix to LANDR. Listen to the mastered output on headphones next to the unmastered mix. Where does LANDR add brightness? Where does it tighten the low end? Write down three things you hear. These are your mix's weaknesses — fix them in your next session.

2. **The style A/B test.** Upload one mix and master it three times using different LANDR style presets (Warm, Balanced, Open). Listen to all three on speakers and headphones. Which sounds closest to your genre's reference tracks? This tells you where your mix sits tonally and what mastering style complements it.

3. **The loudness reality check.** Stream a LANDR-mastered track alongside a commercial release in the same genre at the same volume setting. Is your track quieter? Thinner? Harsher? Use this comparison as a benchmark — it shows you the specific gap between where you are and where you want to be.

4. **The one-day demo challenge.** Write, record, mix, and LANDR-master a complete demo in one day. Not perfect — complete. The time pressure forces decisions. The LANDR master makes it sound finished. Do this quarterly: it shows you how fast you can work when you remove perfectionism from the equation.

Bottom line: Use for demos, social content, and mix diagnostics. Don't use for commercial releases or anything going to a label. Free tier (watermarked) is enough to evaluate it. Basic plan ($9/month) removes the watermark for regular demo work.

07 SAMPLES & SOUNDS

Splice

The world's largest sample library — with AI search that finds what you're hearing in your head

Free to browse · Sounds from $7.99/month splice.com

Splice is a sample marketplace with millions of sounds from professional producers and sound designers. Its AI search lets you find sounds using descriptive language rather than keyword tags. "Dark atmospheric bass that feels like 3am" finds sounds that match a vibe, not just a label. This is how sound selection should work — it's how producers actually think.

How to use Splice properly

- → **AI search for vibe-matching.** Describe what you want emotionally and sonically rather than technically.
- → **CoSo for beat sketching.** Describe a groove and CoSo assembles a beat from Splice's library. Good for hearing a rhythmic idea before committing to building it.
- → **Pack browsing.** Producer packs from known artists are the highest-quality sounds on the platform. Browse by pack when you know the sonic direction you want.

⚡ Try This — 4 Exercises to Do Right Now

1. **The vibe search experiment.** Go to splice.com and search using emotional language: "melancholic piano loop with space", "driving house kick with presence", "warm analogue bass with movement." Compare the results to a basic keyword search ("piano loop", "kick drum"). The AI search finds things keyword search misses entirely.

2. **The sound-first session.** Open Splice before opening your DAW. Find 8–10 samples that feel cohesive — like they belong in the same track. Don't worry about key or tempo yet. Import them and build something from those specific sounds. Constraints breed creativity; a pre-selected palette forces interesting decisions.

3. **The genre pack study.** Find a producer pack from an artist whose sound you want to understand. Download 20–30 samples from it and listen carefully. How are the drums processed? What textures are in the loops? What's the tonal character? You're reverse-engineering a professional's sound palette — this is how producers actually learn from each other.

4. **The CoSo sketch.** Open CoSo on Splice. Describe a beat: "Laid-back hip hop groove, muted kicks, off-beat hi-hats, warm." Listen to what it builds. If the groove has potential, export and develop it in your DAW. The value is in speed, not perfection.

Bottom line: Essential for producers working in sample-based genres. The AI search alone is worth the subscription if you spend time hunting for sounds. Free browsing lets you preview everything — subscribe when you find sounds you actually need.

08 MIXING

Neutron 4

AI mixing assistant that gets your session to a working starting point in 10 minutes instead of an hour

$149 (on sale regularly) izotope.com/neutron

Neutron is an AI mixing assistant that analyses your entire session and suggests starting-point settings for EQ, compression, and balance. The Mix Assistant listens to all your tracks together and creates an initial mix balance automatically. Neutron's suggestions are starting points, not finished settings — the AI gets you to 60–70% of a good mix in minutes; the remaining 30–40% is where your taste and skill come in.

The features worth using

- **Mix Assistant.** Analyses all tracks playing together and sets initial fader levels. Run this at the start of every mix session instead of balancing from scratch.
- **Unmask.** Analyses two tracks competing in the same frequency range and automatically notches each to make space for the other. Use on kick/bass, guitar/vocals — any two elements that are fighting.
- **Track Assistant.** Analyses an individual track and suggests starting EQ and compression settings based on the audio content.

⚡ Try This — 4 Exercises to Do Right Now

1. **The Mix Assistant comparison.** On a session you've already mixed manually, run the Mix Assistant and compare its fader levels to yours. Where does it differ significantly? This isn't about who's right — it's about understanding your mixing instincts relative to an objective analysis. Differences are the most instructive part.

2. **The Unmask experiment.** On any track with both kick drum and bass, load Neutron on both and run Unmask. Compare before and after — does the kick punch come through the bass more clearly? This feature alone justifies the purchase for anyone who struggles with low-end clarity.

3. **The Track Assistant starting point test.** On your next session, use Track Assistant on every track before touching a single control. Listen with all AI suggestions applied. Your corrections to the AI's choices reveal your mixing preferences more clearly than starting from blank — you're reacting to specific decisions rather than making them in a vacuum.

4. **The vocal frequency audit.** Load Neutron on your lead vocal and run Track Assistant. Look at where it applies EQ cuts. These are typically problem frequencies in your recording — where the mic and room are adding colour you don't want. Use this as an education in your specific recording setup's acoustic character.

Bottom line: Buy it on sale (iZotope runs 50–70% sales regularly — check before paying full price). The Unmask feature alone is worth the cost if you mix anything with kick and bass together. It's a starting-point accelerator, not a finished mix.

BRINGING IT TOGETHER

Your AI Studio Workflow

A complete end-to-end workflow from idea to finished demo using the tools in this guide. Pick the stages that match where you actually get stuck.

1

SUNO

Idea generation (10 min)

Generate 5–10 rough concepts. Listen for any element that excites you — a chord, rhythm, texture, lyric fragment. You're not using the output; you're using it to triangulate what you actually want.

2

CHORDAI + HOOKTHEORY

Harmony development (15 min)

If working from a song reference, run it through ChordAI to understand the chord framework. Use Hooktheory to explore variations and understand why the progression works. You now have a harmonic starting point you understand, not just one you've copied.

3

MOISES

Reference deconstruction (20 min)

Use Moises to strip apart your production reference. Listen to isolated stems — how is the drum kit processed? What does the bass do rhythmically? How much reverb is on the guitars? Build a mental model of the production before you start recording.

4

IZOTOPE RX

Recording and repair

Record your demo as normal. Afterwards, run vocals and acoustic instruments through RX: De-noise first, then De-click. Fix problems before they reach the mix. This is the difference between spending mix time improving things vs. fixing things that should have been sorted earlier.

5

NEUTRON 4 + SPLICE

Mix starting point

Run Neutron's Mix Assistant for initial balance. Use Unmask on kick/bass. Use Splice to fill any sound design gaps. Then mix with your own ears — the AI has done the groundwork, the rest is yours.

6

LANDR

Demo master (5 min)

Upload to LANDR for a quick master. Listen to the diagnostic feedback — where does it brighten? Where does it tighten? For demos and social content, the LANDR master is ready to share. For commercial release, get a human mastering engineer.

WHAT'S NEXT

Where to Go From Here

You now have the tools, the context, and the exercises. The one thing that separates musicians who find AI genuinely useful from those who don't is simple: they do the exercises instead of just reading about them.

Start with Moises — it's $4/month and the value is immediate. If you record at home, add iZotope RX next. Everything else can follow in whatever order matches your workflow.

AI doesn't replace the musical knowledge, taste, and feel you've built over years. It removes the friction between you and your ideas — so more of them make it into finished music.

More guides from Cleo

This is part of a series of practical AI guides — covering tools for everyday life, smart home owners, and more. If you found this useful, visit cleoops.com to see what else is available.

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Questions?
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